PREFACE

Written by Software

A language model wrote this book. Every chapter, every table, every sentence you are about to read.

That fact belongs at the front rather than in a note at the back, because it changes what you should do as a reader. You should **check things**. Every claim in this book that comes from Anthropic's documentation carries a numbered reference to the exact page, and those references exist so you can go and look, not so the paragraph appears well-dressed. A book written by software that asks to be taken on trust is asking for something it has not earned.

What software is unusually good at is the thing this book needed: reading a large volume of documentation carefully, holding all of it at once, and noticing where two pages disagree. There are places in here where they do, and this book says so rather than picking the tidier one and moving on.

What software is bad at is knowing what it does not know. That is what the references are for, and it is why one rule outranked every other instruction this book was written under: **no invented specifics**. No company, no customer, no incident, no benchmark, no quotation that is not in a source you can check. Where a scenario appears in these pages it is explicitly hypothetical, and where a number appears it came from somewhere named.

What This Book Is For

You have an exam booked, or you are about to. That is the only reader this book was written for, and it shaped every decision in it.

One rule governs the whole thing. Every paragraph has to **earn its place** against **something the exam actually tests**. Not against being interesting, not against being complete, and certainly not against sounding thorough. If a passage would not help you answer something you would otherwise get wrong, it is not here.

There is a lot of good writing about building with these systems, and almost none of it is organised around what you will be asked. This is not a survey of the field. It is a

working guide to 38 objectives across 7 domains, at roughly 80,000 words, which is a weekend to read and an evening to re-skim.

That length is deliberate. A **book you finish is worth more than a book you respect**, and the ground here is wide enough that a thorough treatment of it would never get read by the person who needs it most.

How the Chapters Are Built

Every chapter has the same parts, in the same order, so you can navigate one you have not read.

A **summary in italics**. What decision this chapter settles, and what it costs to get wrong.

Sections with headers that say what they contain. No teasers. If a header does not tell you something true on its own, it is a defect and you should tell somebody.

Tables, wherever the material has parallel structure. A table communicates in forty words what prose needs four hundred for, and this book has a lot of ground to cover.

Named anti-patterns, in bold. These matter more than they look. Wrong answers on this exam are built out of plausible mistakes, and a mistake you can name is one you can recognise in an option list you have never seen.

A **section on how wrong answers get built**. Families of assumptions that wrong answers rest on, then a three-column table: what the scenario says, what the answer usually is, what the trap usually is. Those rows are written as **cues rather than cases**, so they fire on a scenario set in an industry this book never mentions.

A **closing list of things to remember**. Densely marked, and written so each line stands on its own with the chapter closed. That is deliberate: the one condition under which you will actually read that list is when you cannot see anything else.

How to Read It

If you have **time**, read it in order. The chapters follow the sequence an architect meets the decisions, so each one leans on the last, and the arguments compound.

If you do **not have time**, read the closing lists first, all twenty-one of them, and then read the chapters behind the lines you could not immediately justify. That is a legitimate way to use this book and it was built to survive it.

If you are **checking a specific weakness**, the coverage map in the back matter lists every objective and the chapter that owns it.

One last thing, and it is the honest caveat. **Anthropic's documentation moves**. Numbers change, features ship, pages get restructured. Everything cited here was read on the dates in the references, and any of it could be different by the time you read this. The reasoning will outlast the figures, which is why the reasoning is what this book spends its pages on. But when a number matters to you, follow the link.

Now go and be wrong about something cheaply, on paper, rather than expensively, in production.